

OM PARVAT: THE SACRED MOUNTAIN

Located in the Pithoragarh district of Uttarakhand, Om Parvat is a revered mountain known for its unique rock formation that resembles the sacred Hindu symbol 'Om'. This natural wonder is considered holy by both Hindus and Buddhists and is believed to be the abode of Lord Shiva. Pilgrims visiting Om Parvat as part of the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra experience spiritual solace and a deep connection to their faith. The peak's remarkable symbol, visible from Nabidhang Camp, is a testament to the area's mystical charm and spiritual significance. Om Parvat's growing popularity among devotees worldwide underscores its importance as a pilgrimage site and a symbol of nature's sacred artistry.

STRENGTHENING TOURISM AND LOCAL ECONOMY: DEEN DAYAL UPADHYAYA HOMESTAY SCHEME

The Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Griha Awaas Vikas Yojana is a key initiative undertaken by the Uttarakhand government to enhance tourism infrastructure and support local economies. This scheme aims to offer hygienic, affordable lodging while providing a memorable cultural experience for visitors. The main objective is to foster an authentic experience of the state for both Indian and global travelers. By staying in local homes, visitors get the opportunity to immerse themselves in the region's rich culture, customs, and cuisine. This not only enhances the traveler experience but also helps preserve and promote the regional heritage.

A significant aspect of the scheme is the financial assistance provided to homeowners who wish to convert their properties into homestays. For houses in hill regions, the government offers a capital subsidy of 33% or up to Rs 10 lakh, whichever is higher. Additionally, there is an interest subsidy for the first five years, amounting to 50% of the interest or Rs 1.50 lakh per year, whichever is lower. In the plains, the capital subsidy is 25% or up to Rs 7.50 lakh, with an interest subsidy of up to Rs 1 lakh per year for the first five years.

The scheme also provides support beyond financial aid, including exemption from the State Goods and Services Tax (SGST) for the first three years and hospitality training for homestay operators. There is also a provision for reimbursing the interest on loans up to Rs 30 lakh for necessary renovations and new constructions. Notably, no land conversion is required for upgrading buildings and constructing new washrooms, with a limit of Rs 2 lakh.

Eligibility standards ensure quality and authenticity. The homeowners must reside in the same establishment with their family and can offer 1 to 6 rooms for travelers. The scheme is implemented statewide, except in municipal areas, and registration under the Homestay Scheme is mandatory.

The broader objectives of the scheme include improving the financial condition of locals by providing self-employment opportunities, familiarizing travelers with Uttarakhand's culture, cuisine, and heritage, and generating local employment.

STARGAZING: CELESTIAL WONDERS IN UTTARAKHAND

Uttarakhand's clear night skies and minimal light pollution make it an excellent location for stargazing. Numerous places across the state offer spectacular views of star-studded skies, creating unforgettable experiences for astronomy enthusiasts and nature lovers. Some of these spots include:

- Mukteshwar: A small town known for its stunning night skies, attracting astrophotographers and stargazers.
- Deoria Tal in Ukhimath: A serene lake with a backdrop of Himalayan peaks, perfect for night camping and stargazing.
- Majkhali in Ranikhet: Known for its scenic landscapes and zero light pollution, Majkhali is ideal for stargazing.
- Kedarkantha in Uttarkashi: The Kedarkantha trek, renowned as a winter trek, offers clear stargazing spots.
- George Everest Peak in Mussoorie: Provides panoramic views of Dehradun city and the Milky Way on clear nights.
- Munsiari in Pithoragarh: This Himalayan town offers dark skies and breathtaking views of the Panchachuli Peaks.



> Under the able leadership of PM Narendra Modi, Uttarakhand is seeing transformative growth over the course of time. The undertaking of state-of-the-art ropeway projects and advancements in railways, roadways, and air connectivity is deemed to revolutionise travel and tourism in Uttarakhand. These endeavours not only assure eco-friendly and efficient conveyance but also strengthen our regional economy and generate new prospects for our locals. Uttarakhand's impressive mix of spiritual, adventure, and culture experience makes it a preferred destination for visitors from around the globe. We remain committed to sustainable development, conserving our natural and cultural legacy while making way for thriving tomorrow.
>
> — **Pushkar Singh Dhami,**
> ***Chief Minister, Uttarakhand***



HOMESTAYS: A GLIMPSE INTO HIMALAYAN HOSPITALITY

Staying in a homestay is one of the best ways to experience the Himalayan hospitality of Uttarakhand. Homestays offer budget-friendly accommodation and services provided by local households in picturesque settings. The residents of Uttarakhand are known for their warmth and hospitality, following the age-old Vedic practice of "Atithi Devo Bhava" meaning “Guests are God”.

Homestays are available across several districts in Uttarakhand, offering guests the opportunity to explore rustic locations, enjoy local food, and discover hidden gems with the help of local hosts. Options range from traditional wooden havelis and rustic cottages to modern homes.

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